

work was an ethereal organ piece celebrating the Eucharist (*Le Banquet céleste*, or *The Heavenly Feast*, 1928). Similarly, *La Nativité du Seigneur* (*The Nativity of the Lord*, 1935) was his first truly mature work, in which all the various components of his compositional experiments fell neatly into place.

If religion was the dominant theme of Messiaen's work, the driving force behind his creative impulse was a tireless search for new forms. While still a student, he became intrigued by the possibility of looking beyond the traditional modes of Western music—the major and minor scales.

Over the years, he explored the modes of antiquity, the forms of plainsong, and non-European modes (from India, in particular). He also defined a number of new, modern modes and later codified these as “modes of limited transposition,” writing at length about the seven alternative modes in his book *La Technique de mon langage musical* (1944). Messiaen worked backward, from practice to theory. One of his friends at the Conservatoire, Jean Langlais, described how he found the sounds that he liked through improvisation and then developed a system to accommodate them: “he told me later on, he discovered his system by analyzing his own works, the scales and everything. He did not decide before—he discovered afterward.”

“ I give bird songs to those who dwell in cities ... and paint colors for those who see none. ”

OLIVIER MESSIAEN